Securing Frontier AI in Middle Powers: Project Pitch

Headline summary: "Security is the prerequisite." We help middle powers build the security capacity to host frontier AI safely: convening stakeholders on "best practice" security standards for foreign AI hosting and consulting middle-power institutions on achieving security standards through domestic frameworks.

Outcomes, activities, and relation to middle powers and transformative AI

(a) Outcomes:

Within 24 months, we aim to strengthen the security and enforcement capacity of 2-3 key middle powers so they can host frontier AI safely. First, we will convene parties to agree on best-practice security standards for hosting frontier models. We will then work with prospective hosts to help them build the capacity to meet those standards. This will include building the capacity to 1) protect against the theft of algorithms or model weights and 2) counter AI chip smuggling under the host nation's laws.

(b) Activities:

1. **Government security standards for frontier AI hosting:** Convene key stakeholders (labs, government officials, AI safety researchers) to agree on the best practices host governments need to implement before hosting frontier AI. We will use current research in the field (RAND model weight security framework) as a basis for facilitating the development of security standards that frontier labs and the USG would agree are adequate. We will facilitate these discussions through closed-door dialogues, roundtables and tabletops in pilot countries on two topics: Securing Model Weights and Chip Smuggling Enforcement.
2. Technical assistance to implement agreed standards for frontier AI hosting including:
    a. **Securing model weights and algorithms**: Prevent exfiltration of proprietary information or trade secrets by technical, human, and/or cyber threat vectors from nation-states or malicious actors.
    b. **Chip-smuggling enforcement:** Support enhancement of domestic legislation and investigative and prosecutorial capabilities by developing guidance to help countries crack down on chip smuggling.

Middle powers and transformative AI:

Frontier AI will increasingly be hosted in middle powers. The prerequisite for increasing middle-power leverage by building security capacity in exchange for access to frontier models, depends on these countries having adequate standards, trust and enforcement. Stolen weights and smuggled chips put frontier capabilities in the hands of adversarial states and criminal networks, and any future agreement to slow or limit frontier AI will only work if middle powers can enforce it. We build that capacity now, framed around each country enforcing its own laws and protecting its own access, and are in process of validating this idea with AI safety experts working on compute governance, model security and middle-power policy.

Which middle power(s) or region?

Our leading pilot candidates are the UK, Japan, Singapore, South Korea and a TBD country in the EU (Netherlands, Germany, etc.) chosen because of their potential to host frontier AI capacity and/or proximity to major chip-transit routes.